

NO LOOKING BACK King (fourth from left) with other cast members of the series *Lukkhe*

ON THE FIRST DAY OF HIS SHOOT FOR THE AMAZON PRIME SERIES *LUKKHE*, co-actor Kritika Bharadwaj taught singer-song-writer-rapper and now actor King an important trick. "It was a scene where our characters, Paddy and MC Badnaam, face each other while talking. There was a camera over each of our shoulders. After the first take, she explained to me that in shots like this, I should look at whichever eye of hers was closest to the camera, not both. This is basic, but I had no clue," confesses King, who makes his acting debut with *Lukkhe*.

Born Arpan Kumar Chandel, King rose to prominence with the 2020 Hindi single, 'Tu Aake Dekhle'. He cemented his position as a hitmaker with the track 'Maan Meri Jaan', which was Spotify India's most streamed song of 2023. In the years since, his blend of rap, pop and hip-hop has found international collaborators like Nick Jonas, Jason Derulo, Aland Walker and KSHMR.

Directed by Himank Gaur, *Lukkhe* follows a young hockey player who infiltrates Punjab's rap scene to expose a drug syndicate. Having never acted before, King spent time with the show's writers, Agrim Joshi and Debojit Das Purkayastha, to understand the brooding and volatile Badnaam. There were also weeks of acting workshops with actor-trainer Kulvinder Bakshish. "Sir helped me understand Badnaam's world and what drives him. The first thing he taught me was to not get intimidated by acting," he says.

IN THE EARLY 2010s, KING PAID CLOSE ATTENTION TO THE RISE OF GULLY RAP IN MUMBAI. HE DROPPED HIS FIRST SINGLE AS KING ROCCO IN 2015

Apart from his six albums, King has contributed tracks to Hindi films *Drishyam 2* (2022) and *Shehzada* (2023). But writing, composing and singing for the *Lukkhe* soundtrack was a novel experience. "It was incredible to make music that I got to perform as another character. I had to follow a brief while making 'Headshot', 'Bulletproof' and 'Jee Lenge', but I am also very particular about having creative freedom while making music. Thankfully, the makers liked what I created for the show."

King's journey from government quarters in New Delhi's Chanakyapuri is what pop-star myths are made of. He wrote songs while in school, but football was his whole life. After years of disappointment at selection camps, he gave up on sports, dropped out of college and got a government job. This was in the early 2010s—when smartphones and YouTube's explosive growth altered how we created, consumed and shared media.